mahpiohanzia
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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Angst, Hurt No Comfort, Angst and Feels, Self-Harm, oh no adora has tinnitus, oh no she has everything i have what a coincidence, Author Is Sleep Deprived, The Author Regrets Nothing, The Author Regrets Everything, Author Projecting onto Adora (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Post-Season/Series Finale, author projecting so hard onto adora that next thing you know shes gonna have scoliosis, shes my baby i made her she is mine, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Jealousy, Jealous Adora (She-Ra), Unreliable Narrator, Hatred, Self-Hatred, Feelings, Adora is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), technically set right before scorpias princess ball, envy is the knife that stabs adora, flight as a metaphor for joy and freedom, never outright stated but scorpia and perfuma are together and practially adopted frosta, Mentioned Perfuma (She-Ra), adora has a guilt and inferiority complex, i dont make the rules but actually i do, i wanna make clear that catra is literally the only exception to adoras ideology, its like that mha meme of "kacchan and the others", Mentioned Scorpia (She-Ra), I love her sm, I'm Bad At Tagging, adora may be slightly obsessed with wife, catra also starring as a stand in for salvation, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra Is a Tease (She-Ra), Mentioned Glimmer (She-Ra), Mentioned Bow (She-Ra), Married Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Married Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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mahpiohanzia

by Lukaswritesthings

Summary

mahpiohanzia - noun. "the frustration of being unable to fly, unable to stretch out your arms and vault into the air, having finally shrugged off the burden of your own weight, which you've been carrying your whole life without a second thought."

Adora spent five years physically fighting a war. She'll spend the rest of her life mentally stuck in it while watching everyone around her act like it never happened.

Notes

i should be working on my student gov speech rn but im writing another character study about adora and self harm because i relate to her so terribly
this time i tried not to describe the actual harm part as much and more the feelings leading up to and coming after (trying to study ts so i can accurately ignore my own feelings lmao)
i got the title from the dictionary of obscure sorrows by john koenig because i've been really into his book lately

Adora wasn't really depressed. Perfuma had described it as a constant fog over your head, drowning out your thoughts and dampening every sense. Adora didn't have that, though.

It was similar to the ringing in her ear. A terrible definite that wrapped around her neck and overwhelmed her at the worst moments. It gave her a dramatic sense of longing and listlessness. She wanted something, something unreachable, but she couldn't decipher what it was. Adora wanted it when she woke up, when she hugged her wife, when she watched Glimmer and Bow laugh together like nothing bad had ever happened to any of them. She wanted so much so *badly*. She wanted to forget about the five years she spent fighting a war they'd barely won and only remember the now. Adora wanted to get lost in the moment like her peers did, being able to cheer and throw her hands up during a celebration instead of flinch back and shake out her skin along with the memory of a battle long gone. Were they haunted every night before bed, or was it just Adora that was kept awake by the screams of dead soldiers she'd never learned the names of?

Regarding that, Adora felt such a devastating guilt that her body wanted to curl in on itself and turn to stone. She hadn't even bothered to ask any of the Rebellion's army who they were and what they did. She'd seen their names for the first time ever on a plaque that rested in the middle of Plumeria. Adora had only ever learned their names when they were being remembered for their sacrifice. She'd sat there, next to grieving families, feeling both empty and out of place. There was nothing she could do to change the past, change the fact that they were dead, but Adora didn't feel right sitting next to a mother crying over her lost child while knowing she was the reason they had departed.

It was for that reason, being the cause of so much death, that Adora had tried her hardest to forget their names. It was another fiber to the rope that was tightening around her neck every single day and she couldn't handle it.

After the war, Adora couldn't handle a *lot* of things. It felt like countless battles and hours spent training and fighting had actually made her more frail than anything. Out of everything that she couldn't endure, Adora hated the feeling she got when she saw her friends being happy.

Each of them had done their own therapy with a trusted advisor or two, all but Adora, and they were steadily thriving in every day life. The laid back way in which they could sit at a desk and run their kingdoms without worrying about having to plan a battle every day had clearly done them some good. But Adora's skin crawled whenever she caught someone's gaze as they smiled, eyes twinkling and skin creasing around their cheeks. They all looked older and happier. Adora knew that her smile matched theirs, as it had been perfectly crafted over her teenage years, but she wished she could feel it too. The envy she felt was especially bad around a certain Scorpioni.

While she loved the large woman, Adora wished she could erase Scorpia from existence sometimes. It was a feeling often accompanied by an intense shame when she remembered that Scorpia was a loving person who had her own family and cared for all of her friends with a passion. Then, it came back full force whenever she saw Scorpia smile and laugh. She was so unabashedly happy that Adora could only wonder *why*. Did she not remember how the Horde had treated them? The discipline they had enforced throughout very squadron? Had the Horde not gotten *worse* during the war?

Why was it that Scorpia got to forget about everything and Adora couldn't? Were they not cut from the same cloth? How did Scorpia do it? The questions consistently filled her mind whenever Adora had to be around the other woman for an extended period of time. Each of them whispered in the back of her head louder and louder until they reached a crescendo she couldn't ignore. They led Adora down a rabbit hole of feelings filled with failure and regret. *Regret that she hadn't been the one to pull the sword from the portal.*

So many reminders of the woman and Adora's own shortcomings when the entire day was about her. Scorpia's first princess ball and all Adora could do was sit in her large, pristine bathroom and wallow. She was meant to be getting ready, but how could she focus on anything else but the thought that the next few hours would be spent watching everyone she knew and loved mingle and laugh as if their lives had been perfect. Each show of teeth and peal of laughter reverberated through her skull, mocking her. *They* were mocking her.

Adora's hands formed fists and shook wildly, but they made no move to hit or strike anything around her. She couldn't break anything because it'd become a mess to clean up, and surely Catra would ask questions.

Hey, Adora, why was our mirror broken?

Oh, no reason, I just had a mental breakdown because I hate our friends and myself!

Yeah, the reasoning didn't sound the best in her head, either.

Her nails dug into her skin, and, like a lightbulb going off, Adora got an idea. A few bruises here and there could be hidden by her dress and blamed on a random party goer later.

The first hit stung, but the rest felt... good. It was like finally being punished for something she had been carrying over her head for her entire life. A relief that stung with how sudden it hit her. The constant, crushing weight was still there, but it was the acknowledgement of fault and deservedness that left Adora feeling breathless.

She was no stranger to hurting herself. Adora had spent far too many nights curled up on the training room's unforgiving floor to act like she didn't know how the self-inflicted pain would feel. She had even spent some time getting intimately acquainted with her hunting knife before. However, there hadn't been a time where her own fists had cascaded on her body in any way.

Once she was somewhat satisfied, panting heavily with tears unshed, there was a mottle of yellow skin left behind on her legs. They were quickly forming bruises and she knew they would ache for days.

Adora stared at the offending skin for some time. The previous relief had faded into an emptiness she was familiar with. Having done this so many times, in a variety of different ways, there was no sick adrenaline that asked her *how are we to hide this?* Instead, it felt like she had parted with her body. As if she was a spectator watching a gruesome fight and wondering *had that really happened*? It was like whispering to a bystander next to her and asking *who let this happen? why is nobody helping her?* and only getting the answer when she snapped back to her body seconds later. Throwing her head back and letting it bounce against the wall. Regretting the brutality instantly because of the ball and chain labeled "guilt" that loved to attach itself to her ankle. The reminder that she had a loving group of friends, a wife who constantly worried over her, and a support system who begged her to get help. Another split second clarity that attacked her before the deep cavern in her mind made itself known again.

Like always, Adora was left wanting something more. Something the hits, the knife, nor the constant training was giving her. No matter how far she stretched her aching limbs, Adora could not reach her object of desire, whatever it may be. Waking up every morning felt like standing on her tiptoes and being able to gently scrape her fingertips against it before falling back on her heels. She resisted the urge to scream every time she realized that she was still alive.

"Adora?" There was three knocks on the door. "You in there?"

Catra.

Adora cleared her throat, jolting up from her seat on the edge of their bathtub. A quick glance in the mirror, avoiding the dress hanging up against the door, she saw a sweat-stricken face, red with overwhelming emotion and wild eyes. Although her mind

knew it was her, the person looking back at her seemed like an entirely different entity.

Before she could fall down that line of thought, she answered Catra. "Yeah, I'm, uh, in here. Just putting my dress on."

Adora could hear her wife snicker through the door. "For half an hour almost? You need some help, princess?" Her voice dipped seductively at the end.

Considering her current situation, Adora felt disgusted at the way her stomach turned and a heat began to burn within her at the magi-cats words. Even if she didn't feel such a shame, she knew that neither of them would make it to the ball on time if she took her wife's suggestion.

"No, I'll be out in a minute." Adora reassured. She wiped her suddenly sweaty hands on her boy shorts.

"I'll hold you to it." Adora listened as Catra walked away, her footsteps receding before the squeak of their mattress told her the woman had decided to take a seat and wait for her. With a sigh, Adora compartmentalized all her thoughts of the past 30 minutes. She imagined a tiny She-Ra picking up a bundle of dark, twisting cords and throwing them in the trash bin in the far reaches of her mind.

While not dealt with, it felt significantly better to walk out and join her wife with a smile and an empty brain rather than bog down their interactions with her ramshackle mind so soon. The feelings would catch up to her eventually, likely within the hour as her legs became stiff and immovable. Even now, Adora couldn't ignore the whispers she heard creeping up on her as she tried to lose herself in the expanse of her wife's neck. Nor could she hide the flinch as the ringing in her ears heightened to a scream for just a moment. However, Catra seemed to see right through her, hands sticking to her back and making soothing circles. It was like Adora had projected her thoughts into a shout, as if Catra had seen what terrible things she had done to herself in the name of justice.

Catra, Catra, Catra...

The name rang in her ears, replacing the ringing and deafening screams, until a knock on the door reminded her there were things to do and places to be. Shaken from her appreciatory state, Adora smiled blankly at Bow and Glimmer as they came in. Suddenly, everybody was all wide grins and clapping hands.

And Adora, standing just a bit too far away from the group, felt the claws of her memories sink into her skin like they always did. Trapped once more, Adora could only imagine she looked like a bird in a cage to anybody looking in from outside the suffocating bars.

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